SAT / READING & WRITING / FREE GUIDE

# How to Approach Digital SAT Reading Questions

Find the claim, follow the evidence, and leave tempting distractions behind.

By TestPrepUnraveled • Updated September 12, 2026 • 5 min read

## Read the task first

Identify whether you need a main idea, an inference, a word in context, or evidence. This gives your reading a purpose. Then read the whole short passage rather than searching only for a matching word.

## Summarize in one plain sentence

Name the subject and what the author says about it. Pay attention to turns such as however or although. A detail may support the main idea without being broad enough to summarize the passage.

## Make the smallest supported inference

An inference is a conclusion supported by the text, not a creative possibility. Be cautious with always, never, proves, and entirely when the passage is more limited. Use outside knowledge only if the question requires it; usually the passage is enough.

## Compare choices with evidence

For each serious contender, point to the words that support it. Reject choices that reverse a relationship, add an unsupported cause, or describe only a minor detail. For vocabulary, substitute the answer and check the meaning in context.

YOUR DESK-SIDE REFERENCE

# Quick reference

| Task | Ask yourself | Common trap |
|---|---|---|
| Main idea | What does the whole passage establish? | Choosing one vivid detail |
| Inference | What follows from the evidence? | Adding outside assumptions |
| Vocabulary | What meaning fits this sentence? | Choosing the most familiar definition |
| Evidence | Which choice directly supports the claim? | Matching keywords without logic |

## Original worked example

**Original passage: “A school garden used less water after students added mulch. The plants grew at the same rate as before. The team plans to test mulch in a second garden.” What conclusion is best supported?**

In this garden, mulch was associated with reduced water use without slower plant growth. The passage does not prove that mulch works in every garden or that it always improves growth.

## A tip worth keeping

Before looking at answers, predict the kind of answer you need. Keep the prediction flexible enough to match the text.

## Your quick checklist

- Identify the exact task before working.
- Show the reasoning, not just the answer.
- Review the mistake and try a new example.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE

# Try it yourself

These original questions were written for this guide. Try each one before reading the answer key.

**1. In the example, can we conclude that mulch doubled plant growth?**

**2. Why mention a second garden?**

**3. “The evidence tempered her enthusiasm.” Does tempered most nearly mean heated or moderated?**

## Answers & explanations

1. No. The passage says growth stayed at the same rate.

2. It shows the team plans to investigate whether the result holds in another setting.

3. Moderated. The sentence describes enthusiasm becoming more restrained.

## Keep your prep current

Check your test provider for current rules and format details. These are independent sample guides and contain no official test questions.

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